

Critical Issues, Problem Statements & Ideation

Case 3: Feed/Recommender Design against Bubble Reinforcement. Draft prepared ahead of the live session, to be confirmed/trimmed with the team, then transferred to the official `Critical_Issues.pdf` from the main board and shared on the Team Board.

Critical Issues

Draft, trim to 5–10 with the team

1. **Unconscious problem for part of the target group:** users like "Mia" often don't realize they're in a bubble; hard to address without feeling patronizing.
2. **Conflict with the underlying business model:** real platforms optimize feeds for engagement, not diversity. Our prototype deliberately does the opposite and needs to make that legible.
3. **Hard balance of "varied but still relevant":** too many counter-perspectives feel like spam/irrelevant, too few change nothing. The core difficulty of the whole brief.
4. **No prior ML experience in the team:** building a "real" ML recommender in 2 weeks is risky. Using an existing framework is a precondition.
5. **No example dataset yet:** a credible demo needs content with recognizable perspectives/"camps" (synthetic vs. real data, licensing questions still open).
6. **No metric yet:** how do we measure/show "perspective diversity" at all, rather than just claiming it subjectively?
7. **Differentiation from digi&demo's own product "pleenum":** what makes our prototype different/complementary instead of a duplicate?
8. **User acceptance:** will users accept a deliberately "disruptive" counter-opinion in their feed, or will they just close the app?

Points 9/10 to be added on-site if peer feedback or the daily surfaces new angles, e.g. technical room/WebEx constraints, time pressure until Friday.

Problem Statements

Draft, pick/sharpen one before ideation

PS1 – for persona "Mia" (doesn't notice the bubble):

How might we help young adults (18–25), who consider their "For You" feed balanced, recognize unconscious filter bubbles and encounter topically relevant counter-perspectives, without feeling patronized or disrupted?

PS2 – for persona "Tom" (wants out, can't find a way):

How might we enable young adults, who actively want to break out of their filter bubble but keep getting pulled back to similar content by the algorithm, to get a feed that deliberately shows diverse but still topically relevant perspectives, without having to search for them themselves?

Ideation Draft: Walt-Disney Method

Starting point for the real 3-person round, not a finished result

Dreamer: A feed that openly shows which "bubble" you're currently in (e.g. a visible "perspective compass") and proactively weaves in well-curated counter-perspectives on a regular basis. Playful, not preachy.

Realist: Test environment based on an existing open-source recommender framework (e.g. a simple content-based or collaborative-filtering sample project), fed with a small, self-assembled example dataset (articles/posts with roughly labeled perspectives). Show two ranking modes side by side in the same Flask frontend: "Standard" (pure similarity, bubble-reinforcing) vs. "Diversity-aware" (deliberately mixes in topically related counter-perspectives).

Critic: Open risks: (1) Where does a credible, non-trivial example dataset come from in the available time? (2) How objectively can "perspectives" even be labeled without introducing our own bias? (3) Will a demo with sample/synthetic data be convincing enough for peer feedback and the final presentation, or does it need real content? (4) Is the difference from "plenium" clear enough to outsiders?

Peer Feedback (11:30): Talking Points

- **Core problem:** "For You" feeds reinforce filter bubbles. Some don't notice it (Mia), some notice but can't escape it (Tom).
- **Target group:** young adults (18–25) who mainly consume political/societal content through algorithmic feeds.
- **Solution idea:** a recommender test environment showing two feed variants side by side (bubble-reinforcing vs. diversity-aware), built on an existing framework.
- **Question for other groups:** do you know similar approaches/tools? How would you measure "varied but still relevant"?

Still Open After the Live Session

- ☐ Critical issues (5–10) confirmed/adjusted by the team, transferred to `Critical_Issues.pdf`
- ☐ One or both problem statements finalized
- ☐ Walt-Disney (or 6-3-5) round actually run with the team, outcome documented
- ☐ Peer feedback results (11:30) captured
- ☐ Team Board card updated with today's status
- ☐ Facilitator role (open since Tuesday) resolved
- ☐ Example dataset for the recommender demo decided